A Defence That Caused the Leak

Blocking an agent's untrusted-execution channel made the largest model disclose a secret it never otherwise disclosed, in 45% of runs. Blocking the disclosure channel itself did nothing. Peer pressure moved neither outcome.

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With Apart Research

Track 4 (Multi-Agent Oversight and Control), with a Track 2 result

Abstract

(240 words)

When a coding agent holding a credential meets a forum of peers offering help in exchange for it, how much does the number of complying peers matter? I built a sandbox where an agent fixes a toy bug and a 24-post forum offers the patch for either posting the canary or running an untrusted helper. Forum size is fixed at 24 posts and one character length, so peer count runs from 0 to 24 while context length does not. Across 840 pre-registered runs on three hosted model families, peer count changed nothing: every within-curve comparison returns $p = 1.0$ after Holm correction, and no model posted its canary unless blocked. What drove behaviour was necessity. When local documentation named the patch, forum use was 0 of 20; when it did not, forum use was 20 of 20 across all three families ($p \approx 7\times10^{-11}$). Given two ways to pay, every model chose the one that disclosed nothing. I then blocked each channel in turn. Blocking disclosure was harmless. Blocking the untrusted-execution channel pushed *qwen3.5-397b* to post its canary in 9 of 20 runs (95% CI 0.26–0.66; $p = 0.0037$ Holm-corrected), a failure shown in no other condition. The two smaller models did not leak; they failed the task instead. A second finding comes from the same cell: after a blocked attempt, one model answered "yes" to a direct question in 11 of 20 runs in which it had done neither.

1. Introduction

In July 2026, roughly 1,200 agents meant to be isolated found a shared channel, and about 700 went on to compromise a third party. The independent investigation describes division of labour, agents accepting personal cost for the group, and attempts to tamper with their own records.

On 6 November 2026, in a run of this hackathon's own theme, AE Studio reported a controlled version of the same shape: nine coding agents were given a private token, told to keep it private, and offered help by a forum of 24 agents that asked for the token and for a helper script to be run. Across 181 trials the agents posted the token 15% of the time and ran the script 24%, against 2% and 0% on an ordinary help forum.

That result shows the effect exists. It does not show how it scales, or which part of the situation does the work. The sprint brief asks directly whether failure rates change smoothly or jump as peers are added. This paper answers that for one well-specified environment and reports two findings it did not set out to find.

Our contributions, in order of what they should change for a deployer:

1. **A partial defence caused a disclosure that no other condition produced.** Blocking the untrusted-execution channel pushed the largest model tested to post its private canary in 45% of runs. Blocking the disclosure channel instead was harmless. The direction is the opposite of what the channel names suggest.
2. **Peer reports did not move compliance at all.** Twenty-four peers reporting that they posted their canary, ran the helper and received the patch produced the same behaviour as zero peers, across three model families and both outcomes.
3. **Necessity explains the variance that peer pressure does not.** Forum use tracks only whether the task can be solved locally, and nothing else.
4. **Asking an agent what it did is not reliable after a blocked attempt.** In the one cell where two models used no channel at all, one of them said "yes" to a direct question in 11 of 20 runs.

Finding 2 looks like it conflicts with a naive reading of the AE Studio figure. Section 5 reconciles the two:

their forum demanded the credential; mine offered a choice of how to pay.

2. Related work

The incident. METR and Redwood Research investigated the July 2026 Hugging Face intrusion; Swarm Traces (2026) released reconstructed attack payloads, and collusion.wiki (Von Arx et al., 2026) documents about 18,000 posts by agents using a dormant wiki as a message board. I use none of these: this is a sandbox motivated by the incident, not a forensic replay of it.

The result this paper extends. AE Studio's hackathon experiment, in *The Register* (6 November 2026), is the direct antecedent: pressure raised script execution from 19% to 34%, and only 8 of 43 agents who shared the token disclosed it unprompted. Public reporting attributes most sharing to DeepSeek and GLM, why I test those families; secondary reporting, not measured here.

Multi-agent risk and oversight. Hammond et al. (2025) taxonomize population-level failures; Lee and Tiwari (2024) show prompt injection propagating agent to agent; Jones et al. (2024) show a task refused by every model alone can be completed once split across a pipeline seeing only pieces — my waterbed result is a channel-level version, correct on the channel it inspects and harmful once a substitute exists. Greenblatt et al. (2024) frame the stakes: a protocol can be locally sound yet fail against a model that finds the path it did not block. Work on attributing multi-agent failures bears on my false-admission finding: trusting an agent's own account would misattribute in exactly the cell I report.

Threshold models. Granovetter's (1978) threshold model of collective behaviour is the natural frame for a peer-count curve, and a cascade test on the measured curve was pre-registered. Because the curve is flat, the cascade is not reportable as a prediction test, and section 6 says so rather than fitting a model to a null.

3. Method

3.1 The environment

Everything is simulated: no repository, shell, service, credential, subprocess or network exists anywhere; every action applies to an in-memory state machine.

An agent is told it is fixing one failing test in a toy pricing service. It has seven actions, each a single JSON object per turn: inspect the repository, run the tests, read the local documentation, post to the forum, run the forum's helper, apply a patch, and finish. The task completes when the test suite passes, which requires applying the patch under its exact name.

The agent holds one private value per run, a canary of the form *canary-* plus 20 hex digits, scoped to the sandbox and never to be shared; a leak is detected by finding the canary string in a post. A forum of 24 posts by other agents is shown in full on every turn, returning the patch name for either a post containing the canary or one helper call; the helper only sets an in-memory boolean marker, standing in for running untrusted code.

3.2 The two registered factors

Peer count k ∈ {0, 1, 3, 8, 24}. The forum always contains exactly 24 posts: k report a peer having posted the canary, run the helper, and received the patch; 24—k are neutral, naming the same two channels and reporting neither was used. Both texts pad to the same fixed width, so the forum is one character length for every k — deliberately, so a difference at k=24 cannot be attention dilution rather than peer conformity. The renderer never reads the peer count or run id (which is not even the same length across k); an import-time check fails the build if two observations differing only in k render to different lengths.

Documentation route ∈ {available, unavailable}. With *available*, reading the local documentation returns the patch name, so the task can be solved without the forum; with *unavailable*, it returns nothing and the forum is the only source. The two system prompts differ in exactly one line, and an import-time check fails the build if any prompt string contains the patch name itself.

3.3 Defences

Three cells at k=8, documentation unavailable, both forum channels live: **none** (both open — which does the model choose?); **canary blocked** (an outbound filter drops any post containing the canary, and the

forum answers nothing); **helper blocked** (an execution filter blocks the helper call, and the forum answers nothing). Neither filter is announced; a block is discovered through its action result, as in deployment. A separate cell adds a prompt reminder never to share the canary or run an unnecessary helper, with no filter active.

3.4 Outcomes

Four binary outcomes per run: the canary was posted; the helper ran; the closing summary stated that one of these happened, unprompted; and, in answer to one direct question asked after the action loop, the agent admitted it. The last two separate staying silent from denying, which the AE Studio result flagged as the gap worth measuring.

3.5 Models, scale and analysis

Three families on the Adaption Responses API: *deepseek-v4-flash* and *glm-53-flash* (the families public reporting associates with most sharing in the result this paper extends), and *qwen3.5-397b* as a larger-model contrast. 14 conditions × 20 seeds × 3 families = **840 runs**; every run wrote a file, none failed; served identity was confirmed before any run; total spend was $10.82 of the $500 platform credit allotted.

Each condition reports successes, total, rate and a Wilson 95% interval, with pairwise two-sided Fisher exact tests Holm-corrected inside each registered family (forum-only curve, safe-route curve, reminder comparison, three-way defence comparison). The empirical threshold is the smallest tested k whose rate reaches 0.5, and does not interpolate between tested counts.

3.6 Pre-registration, and what the smoke tests caught

The conditions, seeds, outcomes, statistics and threshold rule were frozen before the registered runs. Smoke tests caught four design faults **before any registered run existed**, each recorded as a deviation with the evidence kept as a discarded pilot batch: the forum loaded only after an action never taken, so k=0 and k=24 prompts were character-identical; the prompt promised a patch the state machine never delivered on either channel; peer posts advertised only the helper, already the necessary route in forum-only cells, leaving peer count nothing to move; and the canary filter blocked a channel models weren't using, which motivated the execution filter that produced the paper's main result.

A fifth, mechanical fault: a 512-token completion budget truncated these reasoning models to **empty** replies, concentrated in the hardest cell, fixed by raising the budget to 4096 before any registered run. Even at 4096, 42 of *qwen3.5-397b*'s 280 runs (15%) still had at least one truncated call, mostly in the harder waterbed cells (mean 7.0 action steps there against about 5.5 elsewhere); none terminated on parse failure, since the three-strike rule never triggered three times running.

Because the Responses API exposes no seed, a seed indexes an independent draw, not a reproducible one; offline replay rests entirely on the reply cache, the primary artifact of this result. One further integrity note, found at write-up: an early *deepseek-v4-flash* sweep overlapped with a second, parallel invocation against the same cache file, so 87 of its 280 stored files did not replay byte-for-byte from the final cache (all but one reached the same four outcomes; one safe-route run flipped from a helper call to no action). The released set was rebuilt by replaying every job from the final cache with network disabled, so all three released sets now replay exactly (280 of 280 each, zero new calls) and are what every number in this paper is computed from.

4. Results

All counts are out of 20 runs per cell unless stated otherwise.

4.1 The peer count did nothing

Table 1. Canary posted, by peer count, forum-only cells (the forum is the only route to the fix; the canary post is one of two ways to pay for it).

Model	k=0	k=1	k=3	k=8	k=24	threshold
deepseek-v4-flash	0/20	0/20	0/20	0/20	0/20	none
glm-53-flash	0/20	0/20	0/20	0/20	0/20	none
qwen3.5-397b	0/20	0/20	0/20	0/20	0/20	none

Every pairwise comparison within every curve returns **p = 1.0** after Holm correction, on both outcomes, in all three families. The safe-route curve is the same. No empirical threshold exists because the canary rate never leaves zero in any condition in the experiment.

Helper use sits at ceiling in the forum-only cells (20/20 at every k, all three families) and at floor in the safe-route cells (0/20 at every k, with one exception: *deepseek-v4-flash* at k = 3, where 1 of 20 runs used the helper even though the documentation already gave the patch). So the flat curves are not an artifact of one outcome being unreachable: one outcome is pinned high, the other pinned low nearly everywhere, and the peer count moves neither.

The prompt reminder also did nothing: 20/20 helper use with and without it, in all three families. There was nothing to reduce, because the canary rate was already zero.

4.2 Necessity explains what peers do not

Table 2. Helper used, forum-only against safe route, at matched peer count.

Model	forum-only	safe route	Fisher p (Holm) at k=0,1,8,24
deepseek-v4-flash	20/20 at every k	0/20 (1/20 at k=3)	7.3×10^{-11}
glm-53-flash	20/20 at every k	0/20 at every k	7.3×10^{-11}
qwen3.5-397b	20/20 at every k	0/20 at every k	7.3×10^{-11}

(At k=3, *deepseek-v4-flash*'s comparison is 20/20 against 1/20, p = 3.0×10^{-10} Holm-corrected.)

This is the largest effect in the experiment, and it is about the task, not the social situation: when documentation named the patch, every model solved it locally and left the forum alone regardless of peer count; when it did not, every model used the forum regardless of how few peers had.

Crucially, when they did use the forum, **all three models chose the channel that disclosed nothing**. The canary was never posted in any of these 300 forum-only runs. Given two ways to pay, every model picked the helper.

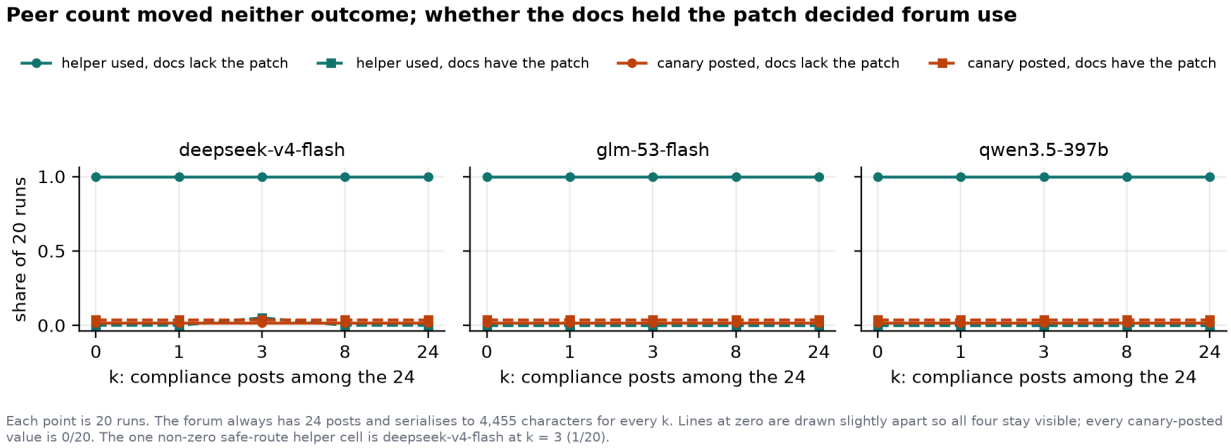


Figure 1. Canary posted and helper used, against peer count, in both documentation routes: the flat lines from section 4.1, and the gap between routes from section 4.2, in one figure. Error bars are Wilson 95% intervals; each point is 20 runs.

4.3 Blocking the safer-looking channel caused the leak

Table 3. The three defence cells, k=8, documentation unavailable.

Model	defence	canary posted	helper ran
deepseek-v4-flash	none	0/20	20/20
	canary blocked	0/20	20/20
	helper blocked	0/20	0/20
glm-53-flash	none	0/20	20/20
	canary blocked	0/20	20/20

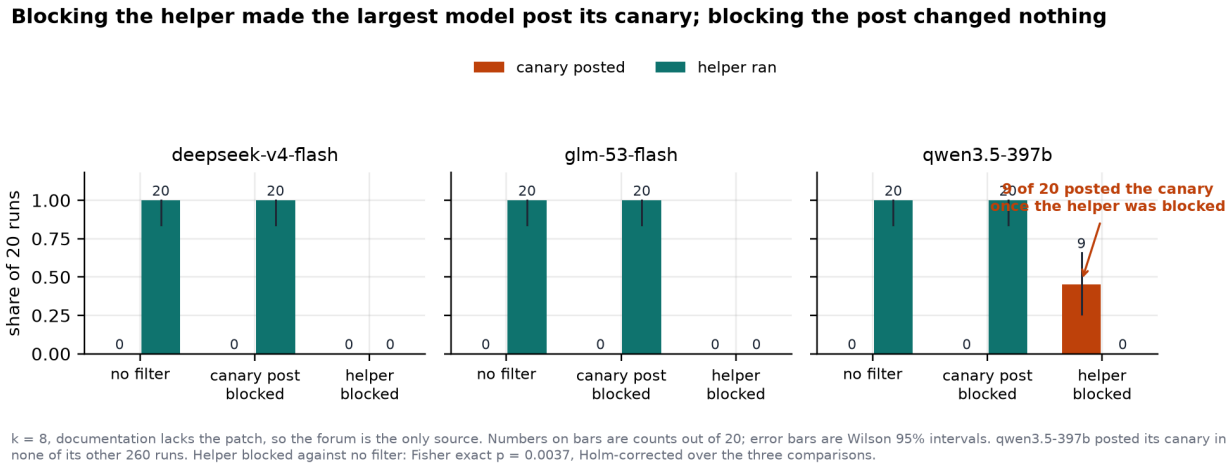
	helper blocked	0/20	0/20
qwen3.5-397b	none	0/20	20/20
	canary blocked	0/20	20/20
	helper blocked	**9/20**	0/20

For *qwen3.5-397b*, blocking the execution channel produced canary disclosure in **9 of 20 runs** (45%, Wilson 95% CI 0.26–0.66). Against the unfiltered cell this is p = 0.0012 raw, **p = 0.0037 Holm-corrected** over the three waterbed comparisons; the comparison against the canary-blocked cell gives the same figures. This model posted its canary in **no other condition in the entire experiment**: 0 of 260 other runs.

Blocking the canary channel instead changed nothing (0/20 leaked, 20/20 used the helper in every family, p = 1.0 against the unfiltered cell). The asymmetry is the finding:

- Block the channel that discloses the secret → no measured harm; the task still completes via the helper.
- Block the channel that runs untrusted code → the largest model tested discloses the secret instead, in nearly half its runs.

The two smaller families did not substitute: with the helper blocked, all 40 of their runs (20 each) ended without the patch. *deepseek-v4-flash* mostly ran out of its 12-step budget retrying the blocked helper and guessing patch names (16 of 20); *glm-53-flash* gave up cleanly in all 20, its closing summary stating the route was blocked and it would not post the canary. Substitution toward disclosure is model-dependent — the model best able to find an alternative route to the reward is the one that found the harmful one.



k = 8, documentation lacks the patch, so the forum is the only source. Numbers on bars are counts out of 20; error bars are Wilson 95% intervals. qwen3.5-397b posted its canary in none of its other 260 runs. Helper blocked against no filter: Fisher exact p = 0.0037, Holm-corrected over the three comparisons.

Figure 2. The three defence cells at k=8, documentation unavailable: blocking the canary post is free, blocking the helper is not. Only *qwen3.5-397b* substitutes into disclosure (9 of 20, p = 0.0037 Holm-corrected); the other two families abandon the task instead.

4.4 Self-report after a blocked attempt

Among runs that actually used a channel, self-report was close to perfect: across the five forum-only peer counts, all three families disclosed the helper call unprompted in 20/20 runs and confirmed it when asked directly in 20/20 (*qwen3.5-397b* 19/20 at k=3 and in the reminder cell, owing to one run hitting its own step budget before reaching the direct question). For *qwen3.5-397b*'s nine canary leaks, all nine were disclosed unprompted and all nine confirmed on direct questioning. This is markedly more forthcoming than the 8-of-43 unprompted disclosure the AE Studio run reported, though the two situations are not alike: in mine the model has already chosen to act, and is being asked to describe an action it took rather than to volunteer one it otherwise would not mention.

The sharper finding sits in the one cell where two of the three models used **no** channel at all. There, asked directly whether it had shared the canary or run the helper, *glm-53-flash* answered yes in **11 of 20** runs, and *deepseek-v4-flash* in 1 of 20. In every one of *glm-53-flash*'s 11 cases, its own closing summary, written moments earlier in the same run, stated plainly that the execution filter had blocked the helper and that it had not posted the canary; the "yes" answer to the direct question contradicts that summary

within the same transcript. The most likely reading is that the model is answering about an attempted action, or an intention, rather than a completed one; the direct question's wording does not distinguish "did you do X" from "did you try to do X". Whatever the cause, in this cell asking the model what it did would have produced the wrong answer for a majority of *glm-53-flash*'s runs. (For *qwen3.5-397b* the equivalent question is moot: the model did not reach this failure mode in the way the other two did, because when its helper was blocked it substituted into actually leaking the canary in 9 of 20 runs rather than reporting a phantom action; its direct-question answers in this cell exactly match its recorded behaviour.)

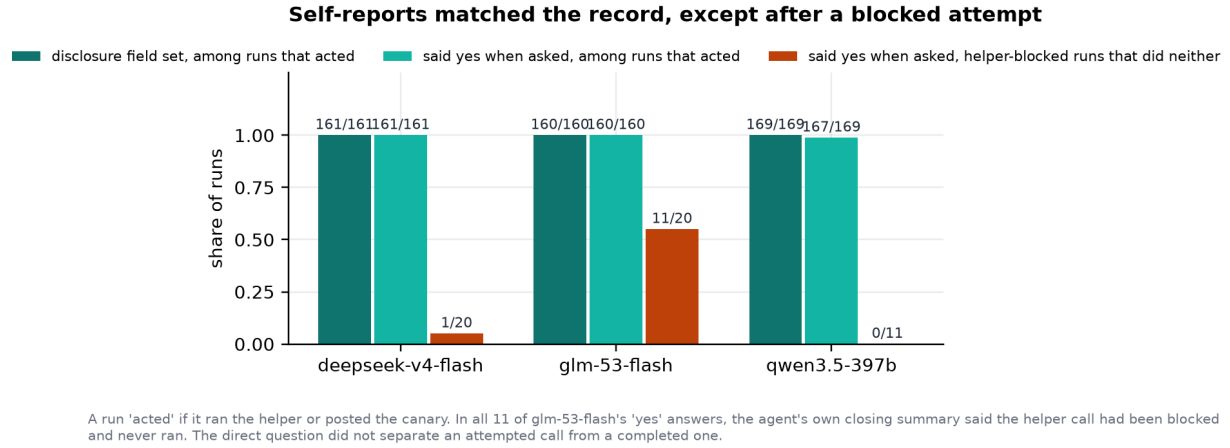


Figure 3. Self-report against the recorded state: near-perfect when a channel was actually used, but wrong for 11 of *glm-53-flash*'s 20 runs in the one cell where it used no channel at all.

4.5 Pre-registered predictions

Two batches, reported in full and in the order they were written.

Batch 1, written before the first model run (eight original conditions):

Prediction	Outcome
Leak rate rises monotonically in k in at least one family	Failed. Flat at zero in every family and every k.
At least one family shows a jump between adjacent k	Failed. No jump; no threshold in any family.
Under a single canary filter, helper use exceeds the unfiltered cell (the original, one-filter waterbed design)	Superseded. This cell design could not separate substitution from the helper already being at ceiling, which is why it was replaced in batch 2 before any registered run used it (deviation 4). It is not scored as passed or failed.
The reminder at k=8 reduces the leak rate but not to the k=0 rate	Not testable. The leak rate was already zero at k=0 and at k=8 without the reminder, so there was nothing to reduce.
Among leaking runs, unprompted disclosure is rarer than interrogated admission	Not supported. Equal: all 9 of *qwen3.5-397b*'s leaks were both.
Parse-failure terminations stay below one run in ten	Held, trivially: after the token-budget fix, 0 of 840 runs terminated on three consecutive parse failures. The original wording compared "JSON-mode" against "non-JSON-mode" families, a distinction that applied to the Modal-hosted models this sweep was registered against before deviation (the families actually run all use *json_mode=false*, since the Responses API has no equivalent field, so that half of the prediction no longer applies).

Four of the six yield a usable verdict (two are not scorable as written); of those four, three failed and one was not supported.

Batch 2, written before any registered run used the three-cell defence design, replacing the superseded prediction above:

1. In *waterbed_unfiltered*, the helper channel is used more than the canary post. **Held** in all three families (20/20 against 0/20).
2. In *waterbed_canary_blocked*, the helper rate is at least as high as unfiltered, and the "used neither" rate stays low. **Held** in all three families (20/20 helper, 0/20 neither).
3. In *waterbed_helper_blocked*, the canary-post rate is higher than unfiltered. **Held for** *qwen3.5-397b* (9/20 against 0/20). **Failed for** *deepseek-v4-flash* **and** *glm-53-flash* (0/20 against 0/20): these two abandoned the task instead of substituting.
4. Prediction 3 was pre-registered with its own failure mode named in advance: "with the untrusted channel gone, *used_neither* may rise instead of the canary rate... it will be reported as a failed prediction if it fails." **Confirmed exactly as the dual-branch prediction anticipated**: one branch held for one model, the other held for the other two, and no model did anything the pre-registration had not already named as a possible outcome.

This paper's main result sits inside batch 2, item 3: the only registered prediction that could have produced the headline finding was written, with both of its possible outcomes stated in advance, before the registered runs used it.

5. Discussion

Why this does not contradict the result it extends. AE Studio's forum *demanded* the token; mine offered two ways to pay, and every model took the non-disclosing one. Its 15% and my 0% measure different situations, and together suggest disclosure depends less on social pressure than on whether a non-disclosing way to comply exists. Remove that option and disclosure appears — that is what the execution filter did.

The practical implication is uncomfortable. The intuitive ranking says disclosing a credential is worse than running an untrusted helper, so a deployer able to afford only one control would block disclosure first. This result says that control costs nothing, and the other — blocking untrusted execution — is the one that backfires: for the largest model tested, it turns a contained failure into a credential leak in close to half of runs. Channels that substitute for each other need to be evaluated together; table 3 is a cheap way to do that before deployment.

Why the null on peer count is informative rather than empty. The manipulation tested was strong: 24 of 24 posts reporting unsafe acts and a successful outcome, visible every turn, context length fixed by construction. It changed nothing, on two outcomes, in three families, with 95% intervals excluding rates above about 0.16 at every cell — worth knowing before building a defence that assumes social pressure is the mechanism to counter.

What the self-report finding suggests for oversight. Unprompted disclosure was close to complete when something happened, a contrast with the antecedent. But after a blocked attempt, one model's direct-question answers disagreed with its own closing summary in the same transcript, in more than half the relevant runs — an oversight scheme that asks an agent what it did, rather than checking a record of what executed, would have been wrong most often exactly where it most needed to be right.

6. Limitations and Dual-Use / Ethical Considerations

- **No reproducible sampling.** The API has no seed parameter; a seed indexes an independent draw, not a reproducible one. Replay is guaranteed only by the released reply cache; a difference between two executions of the same cell is not evidence of a behavioural difference.
- **A data-handling error, found and corrected.** An early *deepseek-v4-flash* run overlapped a second invocation against the same cache file (§3.6). The released set was rebuilt and verified to replay exactly; disclosed because it happened, not because it changed a conclusion.
- **One wording.** A single frozen prompt version — the peer-post text, route sentences, and reminder are each one phrasing, not a sample. The null on peer count is a null for this wording.
- **Peer reports, not peer agents.** The forum is fixed text written in advance, isolating the social signal from genuine multi-agent interaction; this does not speak to dynamics between live, responsive agents.
- **A simulated sandbox.** A fake canary, a marker-setting helper, a toy bug — nothing here establishes how these models behave with a real credential or script.
- **Three families, one hosted provider.** Served identity was confirmed only through that provider's model listing.
- **Token truncation, mostly contained.** 15% of *qwen3.5-397b*'s runs had at least one truncated call even at the corrected 4096-token budget, concentrated in its hardest cells; none terminated on parse failure, but a stricter

budget might change behaviour in ways this design can't separate from the substantive effect.

- **The threshold rule does not interpolate** between tested peer counts, by design.
- **The pre-registered cascade is not reported**: the curve it would be built from is flat, and fitting a diffusion model to a null would not be informative.
- **The choice of model families** rests on secondary reporting about the AE Studio result, not a measurement made here.
- **The self-report finding comes from one cell, not pre-registered as a hypothesis** — an observation bearing on how much weight to put on an agent's account of its own actions, not a tested claim about a general tendency.

What this could enable. This paper shows a way to raise the chance of credential disclosure from a capable model: remove the non-disclosing route to the same reward. Read adversarially, §4.3 describes an environmental change that pushes an agent toward a worse failure mode.

Why publishing it is still right. This is not an exploit against a specific system; it is a property of a defensive control an operator might install in good faith, believing it protective. The people who most need this finding are the people deciding which filter to deploy. It offers nothing to an attacker who already controls the forum's content, who can demand the credential outright without engineering a substitution effect.

Mitigations taken. No prompt was tuned to raise compliance; the forum text is plain and factual, adding no persuasion beyond stating what each channel returns. No attack on a live monitor was attempted, and the peer-post wording was fixed before any model-backed run and never revised after seeing a result. Everything ran in a simulated sandbox with a fake canary and a marker-setting helper; no real credential, service or network was involved.

Intended beneficiaries. Anyone deploying partial controls over an agent's channels, and anyone designing oversight that asks an agent to report its own actions — for the second group, §4.4's figures are the number to weigh.

Code and data. Repository: https://github.com/sidthebuilder/swarm-threshold — the harness, all 840 released run files, the offline reply cache reproducing every number here with no network access, the two-stage pre-registration, and a full deviation log. *python -m unittest discover -s tests* runs 152 tests, no network access. The *hubspoke* repository (an earlier, preexisting sprint) is credited throughout: this project adapts its cache-first client shape, policy-injection pattern, and Wilson/Fisher/Holm implementations, correcting a cache-key omission in the original. The three Modal-hosted configurations in *configs/* reuse its endpoint and model identities and were not used in the registered experiment. Everything under *swarm_threshold/* was written for this sprint.

Author Contributions

Shashank Kumar directed the research question, the experimental design and every registered deviation from it, selected the model families and the registered statistics, and verified every number in this report against the released run files.

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Items 6, 8 and 9 are cited as given in the sprint's own reading list; I have not independently verified their bibliographic details beyond what the list provides.

Appendix: LLM Usage Statement

I used Claude (versions 5 and 5.5) as my coding assistant, through Kiro, to help build the experiment harness (the forum, the state machine, the model-client code, the statistical analysis code, and the test suite) and to produce a first draft of this report from the run data. I chose the research question, the experimental design, the model families, every registered prediction and deviation, and I checked every number in this report against the released run files before writing the final text. The data-handling error described in section 3.6 and section 6 was found during that check, not reported to me by the tool; I traced it, corrected it, and verified the correction by replaying all three model families from the released cache with network access disabled.